

THE DOVE

Columba



SIZE RANKING	54
BRIGHTEST STAR	Phact (α) 2.7
GENITIVE	Columbae
ABBREVIATION	Col
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.	January
FULLY VISIBLE	46°N–90°S

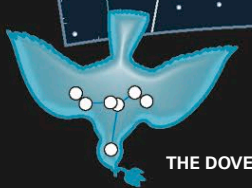
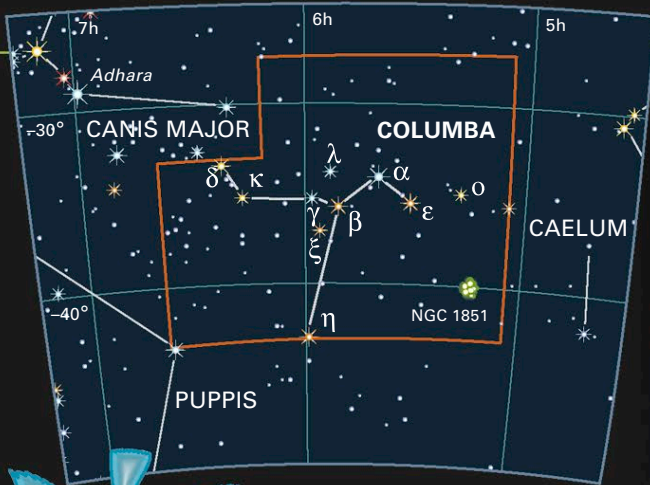


The Dutch theologian and astronomer Petrus Plancius (see p.358) formed this southern constellation in the late 16th century from stars near Lepus and Canis Major that had not previously been allocated to any constellation. It supposedly represents Noah's dove (see panel, right).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Fifth-magnitude Mu (μ) Columbae is a fast-moving star apparently thrown out from the area of the Orion Nebula about 2.5 million years ago. Astronomers think that it was once a member of a binary system that was disrupted by a close encounter with another star. The other member of the former binary, moving away from Orion in the opposite direction, is 6th-magnitude AE Aurigae.

NGC 1851 is a modest globular cluster that is visible as a faint patch through a small telescope.



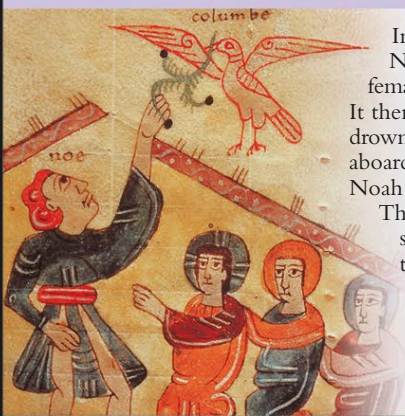
THE DOVE

BIRD WITH A MISSION

In this image, north is to the left and the stars of Puppis and Canis Major lie beneath Columba, the Dove, which flies through the southern sky.

MYTHS AND STORIES

NOAH'S DOVE



In the Biblical story of the Flood, Noah loaded an ark with a male and female of every kind of animal on Earth. It then rained for 40 days and 40 nights, drowning everything except the animals aboard the ark. When the rain abated, Noah sent out a dove to find dry land. The dove came back with an olive stem in its beak—a sure sign that the waters were at last receding.

WINGED MESSENGER

The dove returns to Noah's Ark, carrying an olive branch, in this illustration by a 10th-century Catalan monk named Emeterio.

THE COMPASS

Pyxis



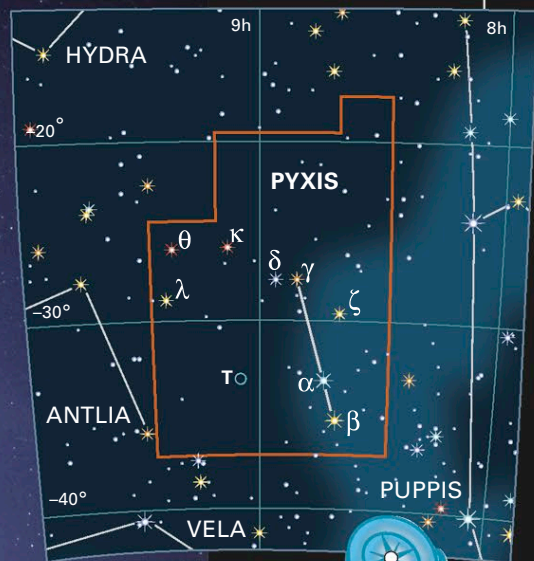
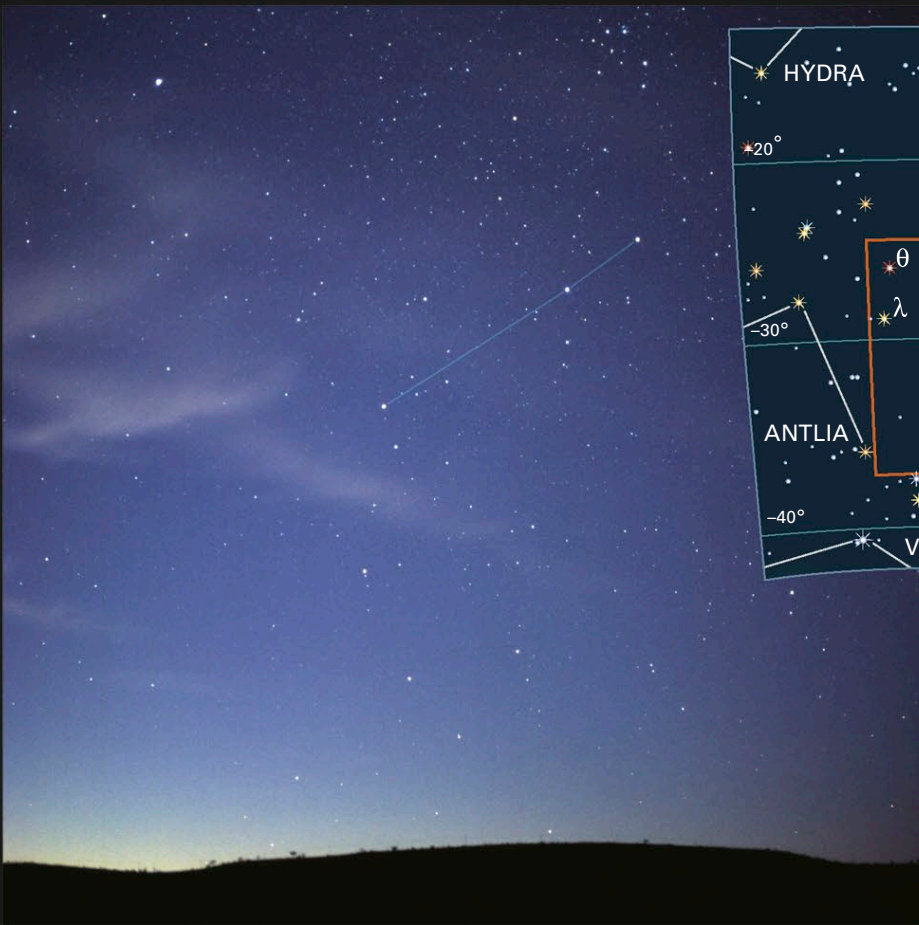
SIZE RANKING	65
BRIGHTEST STAR	Alpha (α) 3.7
GENITIVE	Pyxididis
ABBREVIATION	Pyx
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.	February–March
FULLY VISIBLE	52°N–90°S



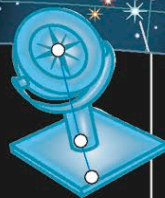
Pyxis is a faint and unremarkable southern constellation lying next to Puppis on the edge of the Milky Way. It represents a ship's magnetic compass. The constellation was introduced in the 18th century by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

T Pyxididis is a recurrent nova—that is, one that has undergone several recorded outbursts. Six eruptions have been seen since 1890, the last being in 2011. During these outbursts, it has brightened to 6th or 7th magnitude. It is likely to brighten again at any time and become visible through binoculars.



THE COMPASS



COMPASS BEARINGS

In this image of the scattered stars of Pyxis, the Compass, north is on the left, and the stars of adjacent Puppis are to be found above Pyxis.